

Frequency Fitness Assignment as a Research Direction

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Outline

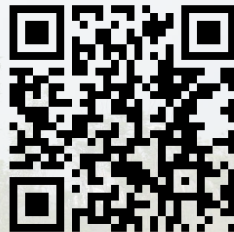


1. Introduction
2. Research Field: Optimization
3. Research Direction: Frequency Fitness Assignment
4. Our Results
5. Future Works
6. Summary
7. Advertisement





Introduction



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- Our team has two general research directions: Optimization¹⁹⁷ and Artificial Intelligence (AI).



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- My students and I are members of the Optimization Direction.
- Today, I therefore want to first give a short introduction into the field of optimization, before delving into one of our concrete research topics, namely Frequency Fitness Assignment (FFA).

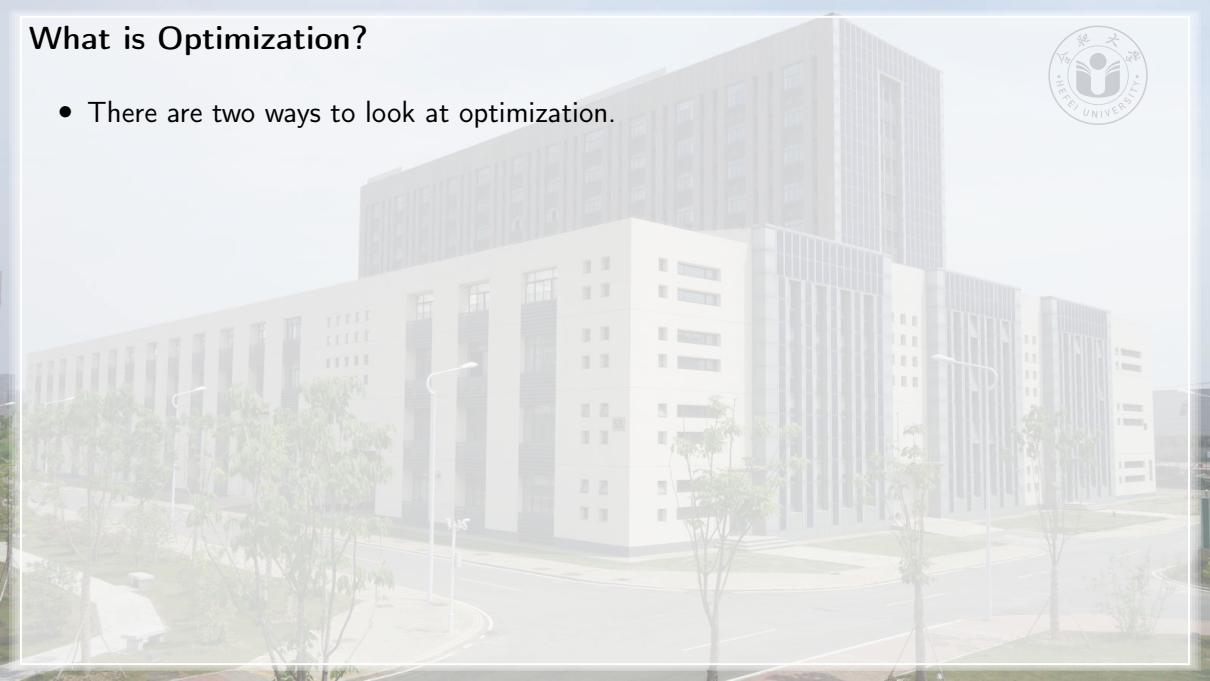


Research Field: Optimization



What is Optimization?

- There are two ways to look at optimization.



What is Optimization?

- The economic view.

Optimization Problem

An optimization problem is a situation which requires deciding for one choice from a set of possible alternatives in order to reach a predefined or required benefit at minimal costs.



What is Optimization?

- The mathematical view.

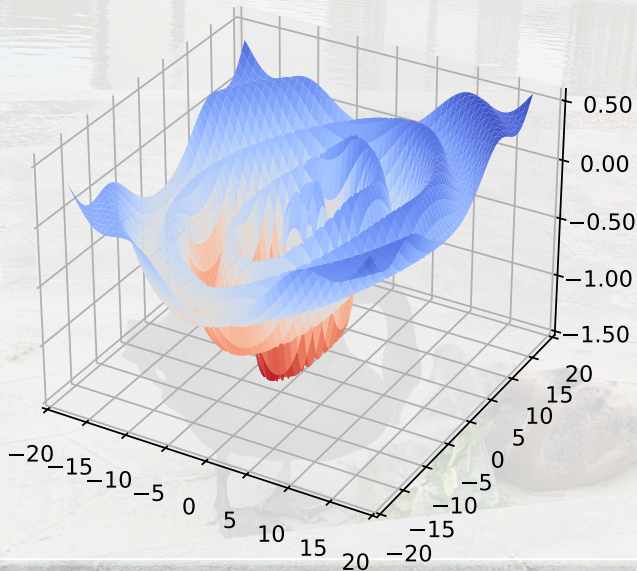


Optimization Problem

An optimization problem is a situation which requires deciding for one choice from a set of possible alternatives in order to reach a predefined or required benefit at minimal costs.

Solving an optimization problem requires finding an input element x^* within a set $\mathbb{X}$ of allowed elements for which a mathematical function $f: \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ takes on the smallest possible value.

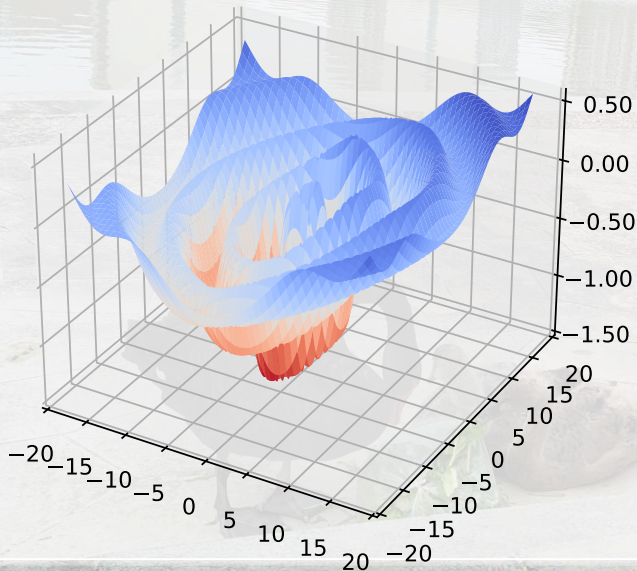
Example: Function Optimization



- In the field of continuous optimization, we could literally try to find the **minimum** of a mathematical function $f: \mathbb{R}^n \mapsto \mathbb{R}$.

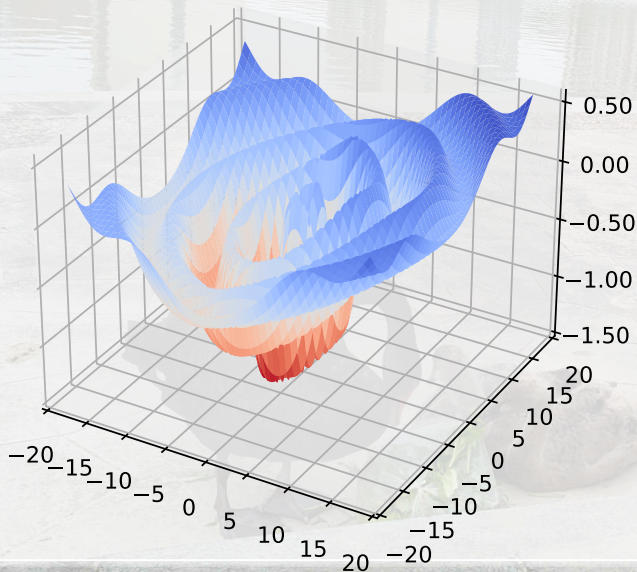


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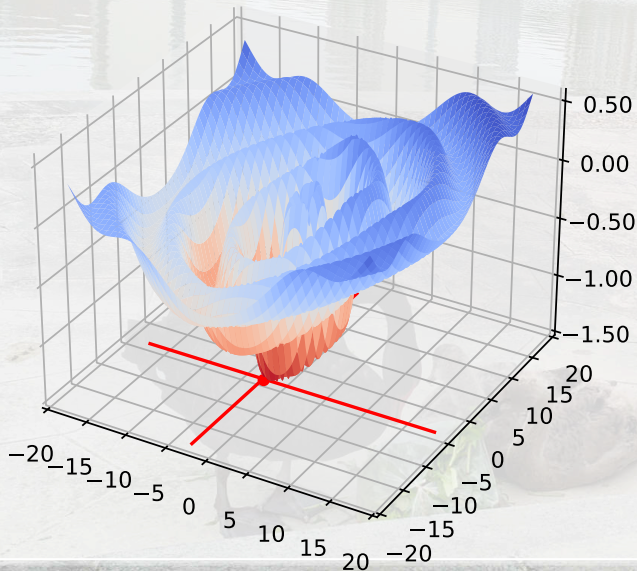
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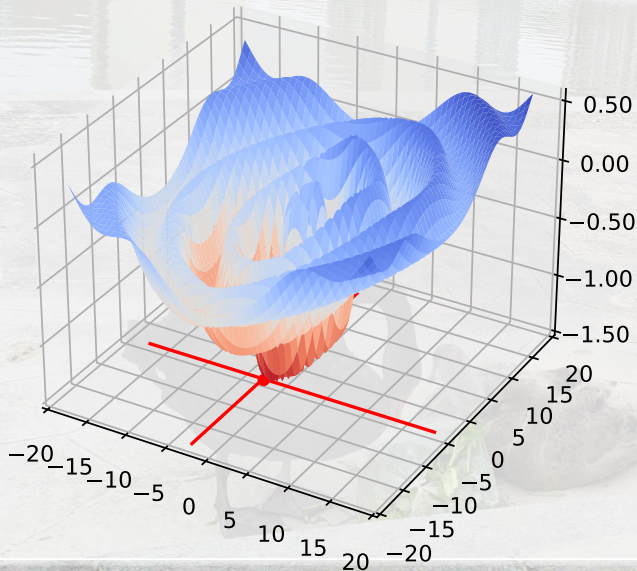
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- **This is *not* what I am working on, though.**

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- In the Traveling Salesperson Problem (TSP)^{4,90,121,125,201,209}, the goal is to find the shortest round-trip tour through a set of n cities.



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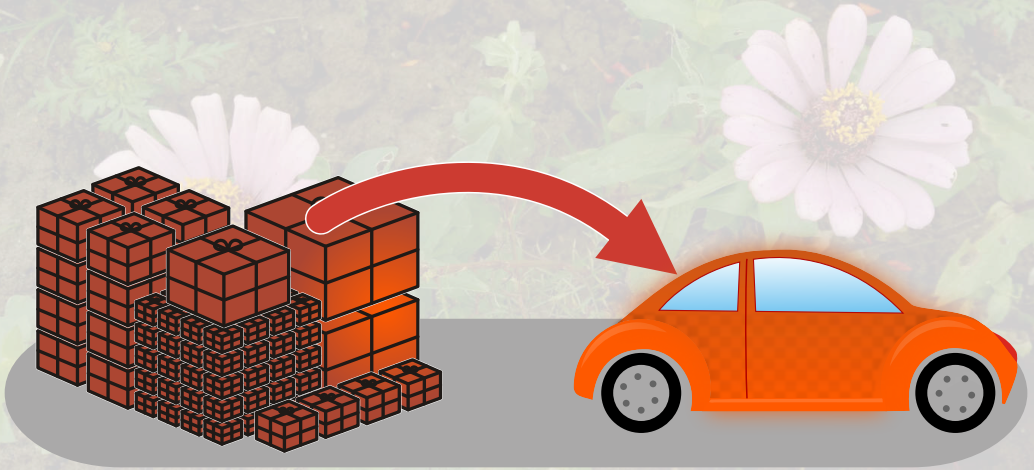
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- The optimal solution $x^* \in \mathbb{X}$ is the shortest possible tour.



Example: Bin Packing Problem



- The goal of the Bin Packing Problem is to pack n objects, each having a specific size, into as few bins (also of a given size) as possible^{219,220}.



Example: Bin Packing Problem



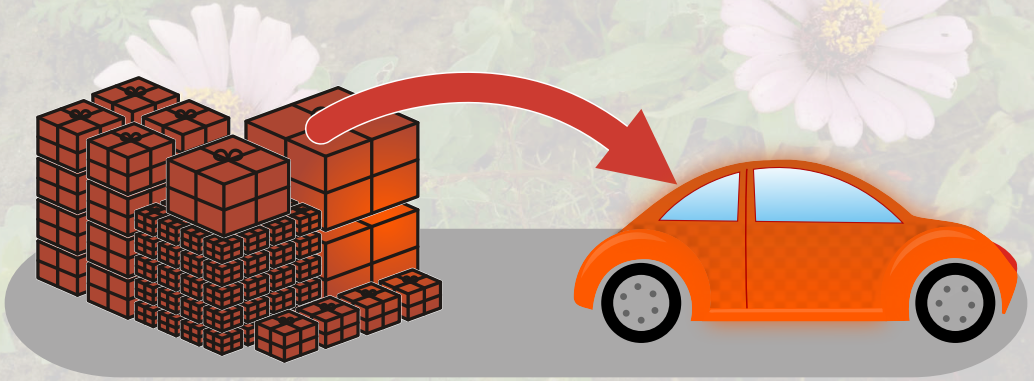
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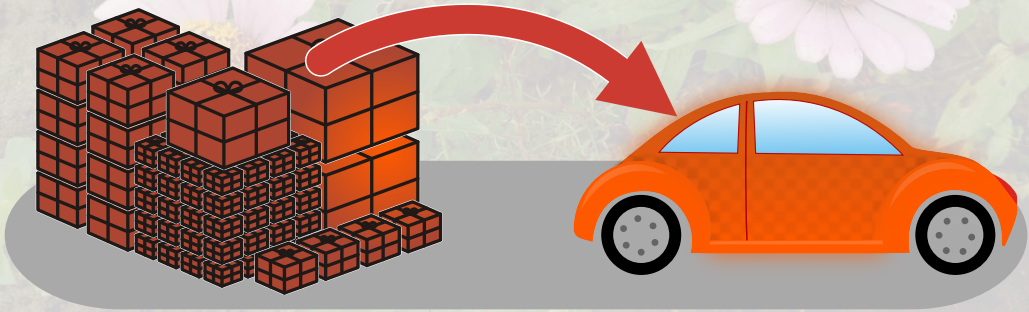
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- The optimum x^* is the packing order requiring the fewest bins.



Optimization is Hard

- Finding the globally optimal solution x^* from the set of all possible solutions $\mathbb{X}$ is often an $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard problem.



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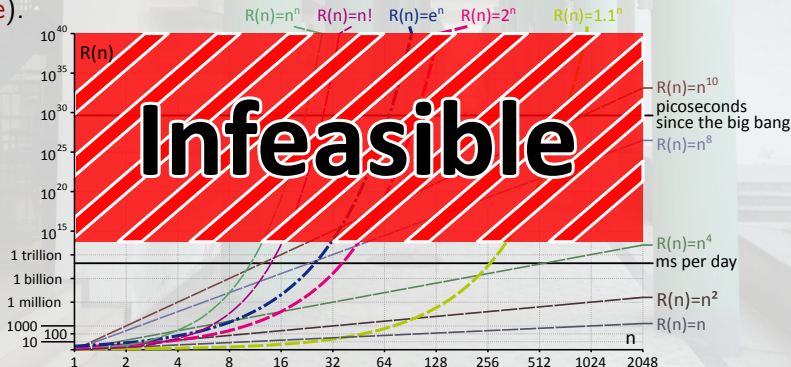


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- Currently, there is no algorithm that can **guarantee** to find the optimal solution of **every instance** of a given $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard problem in a runtime that is not longer than polynomial in the size of the problem (i.e., existing algorithms may need exponential runtime in the **worst case**).

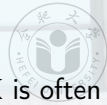
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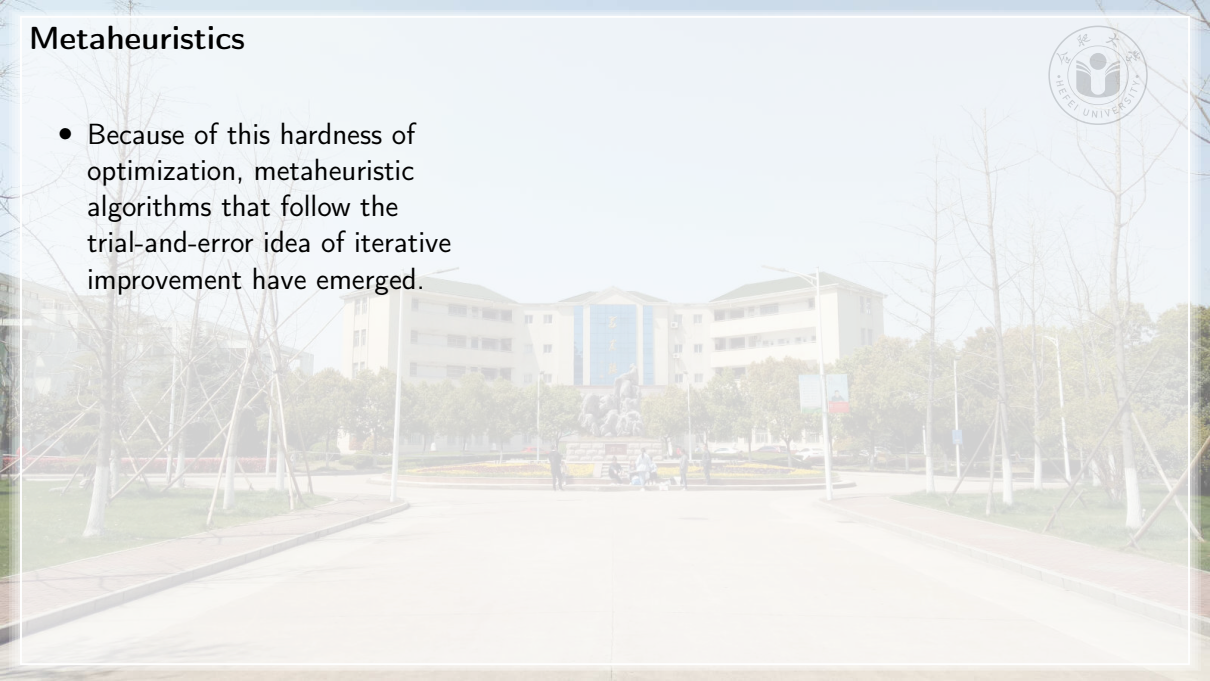
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- In other words, if we want to guarantee to find the best possible solution x^* for all possible instances of a problem, we often cannot really be much faster than testing all possible candidate solutions $x \in \mathbb{X}$ in the **worst case**.

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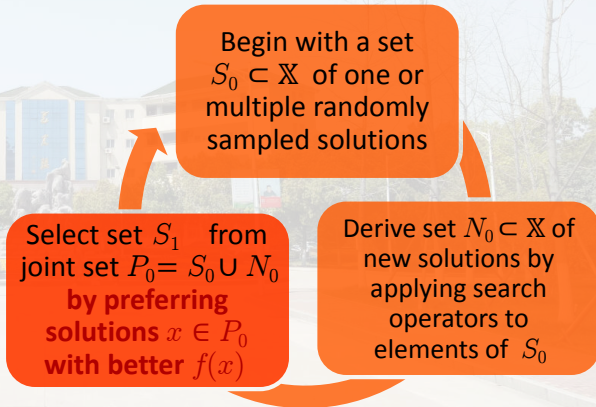
Derive set $N_0 \subset \mathbb{X}$ of new solutions by applying search operators to elements of S_0



Metaheuristics



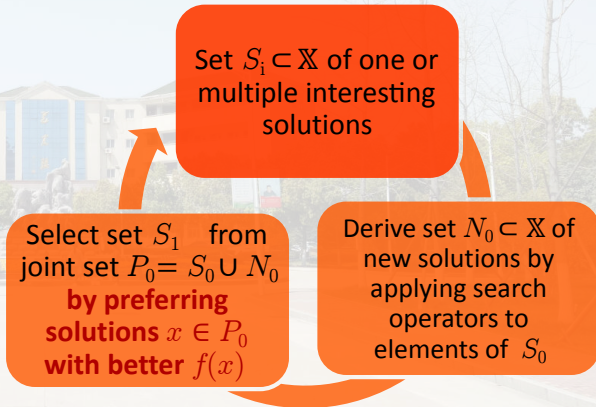
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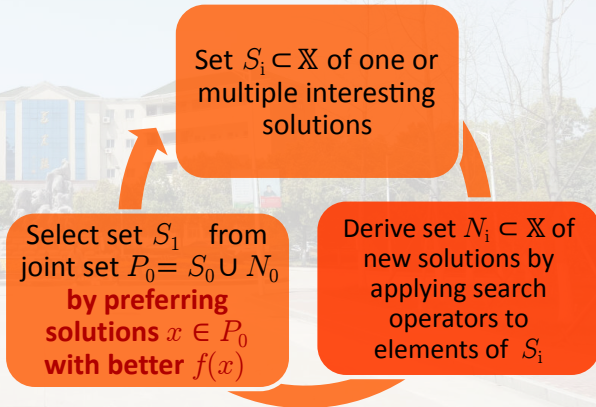
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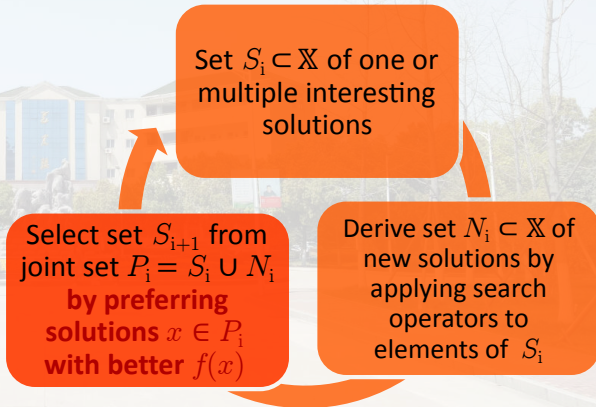
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RLS and the $(1 + 1)$ EA



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  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
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Simulated Annealing

- Simulated Annealing (SA)¹¹⁰ is a local search that accepts also worsening moves, but with a probability that decreases over time and with the difference in solution quality.



Simulated Annealing



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- Let's start with RLS/(1 + 1) EA and modify it to become SA.

```
procedure SA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}, T_0, \varepsilon$ )  
  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$   
  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$   
  
    if  $y_n \leq y_c$  then  
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- $\mathcal{R}_0^1$ be a random number uniformly distributed in $[0, 1)$.

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    if  $\mathcal{R}_0^1 < e^{\frac{y_c - y_n}{T}}$  then  
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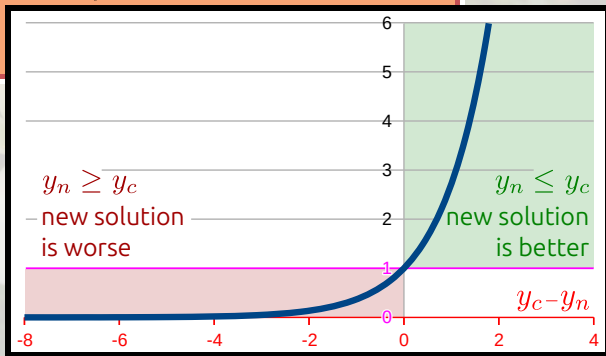
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while $\neg$ terminate **do**

$x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$; $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$;

if $\mathcal{R}_0^1 < e^{-y_c - y_n}$ **then** $\triangleright$ always true if $y_n \leq y_c$

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- High temperatures T increase the acceptance probability P of worse solutions, low T reduce it.

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   $\tau \leftarrow 0$ ; ▷  $\tau$  is iteration counter  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
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       $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ 
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Simulated Annealing



- Simulated Annealing (SA)¹¹⁰ is a local search that accepts also worsening moves, but with a probability that decreases over time and with the difference in solution quality.
- $\mathfrak{R}_0^1$ be a random number uniformly distributed in $[0, 1)$.
- High temperatures T increase the acceptance probability P of worse solutions, low T reduce it.
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Simulated Annealing



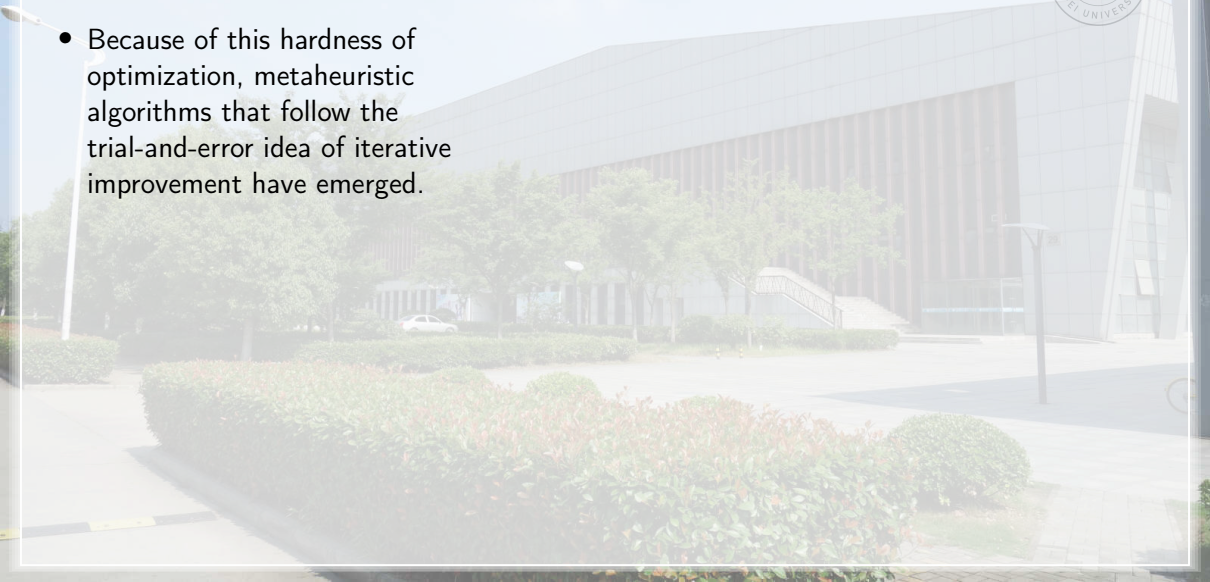
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Metaheuristic Optimization



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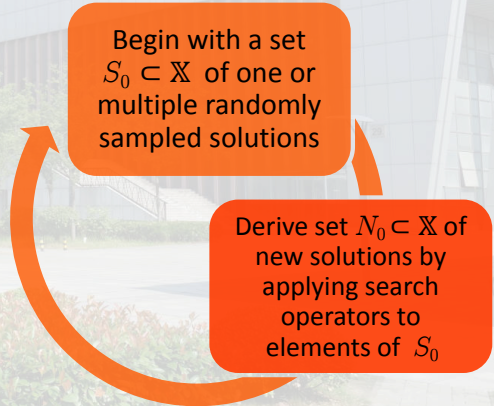
A large orange circular arrow diagram, with the text box at the top and an arrow pointing back to itself, indicating a cycle.

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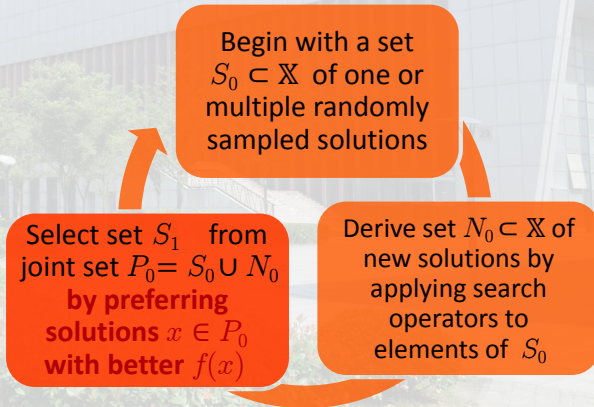
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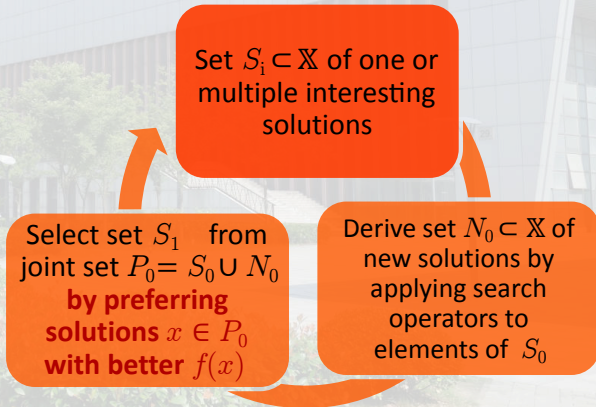
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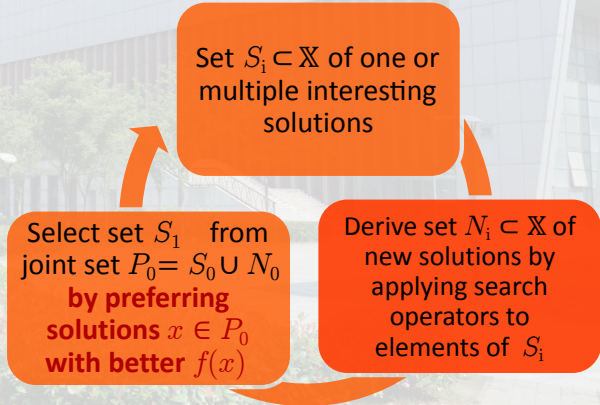
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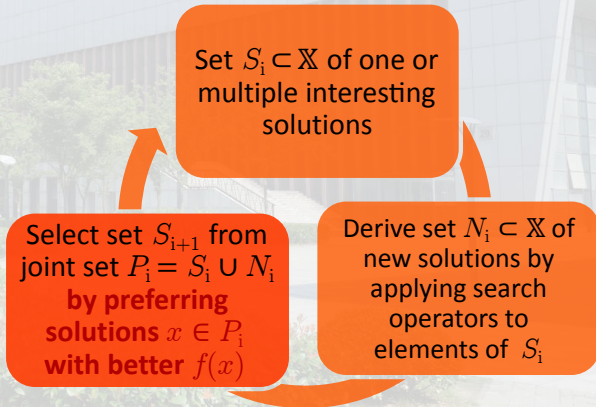
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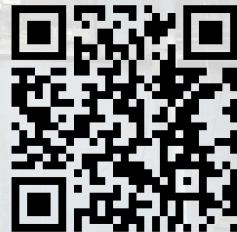
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- We investigate classical hard problems that have discrete search spaces, such as bit strings or permutations.
- Here, the objective functions take on only natural numbers in $\mathbb{N}_0$.
- We try to enable metaheuristic algorithms to find better solutions for these problems.



Research Direction: Frequency Fitness Assignment



Metaheuristic Optimization Algorithms



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If you keep good solutions and modify them, you are likely to get better solutions.

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- Algorithms like random sampling or exhaustive enumeration that do not at least statistically prefer better solutions have extremely bad performance.
- We **challenge** this principle.
- Our Frequency Fitness Assignment (FFA) does **not** prefer better solutions ... yet it can improve the performance of existing algorithms in several cases!

FFA: Idea



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- Before the selection step of the algorithm, $H[f(P_i[j])]$ for all $j \in 1..|P_i|$ is incremented by 1.
- Then, the frequencies $H[f(P_i[j])]$ replace the objective values $f(P_i[j])$ in the actual selection decisions.

FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA



- Let's plug FFA into the (1 + 1) EA and obtain the (1 + 1) EA with FFA ((1 + 1) FEA).

```
procedure (1 + 1) EA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ )  
  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$ ;  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$ ;  
    if  $y_n \leq y_c$  then  $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
```

FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA



- We start with the (1 + 1) EA.

```
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```
procedure (1 + 1) EA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{N}$ )
```

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- We begin by initializing the frequency table H with all zeros.

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```
procedure (1 + 1) FEA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{N}$ )  
   $H \leftarrow (0, 0, \dots, 0)$ ;  
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FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA



- *Before* the selection decision, we increment the frequency values of the objective values of all current solutions.

```
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  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$ ;  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$ ;  
    if  $y_n \leq y_c$  then  $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
```

```
procedure (1 + 1) FEA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{N}$ )  
   $H \leftarrow (0, 0, \dots, 0)$ ;  
  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$ ;  
  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$ ;  
     $H[y_c] \leftarrow H[y_c] + 1$ ;  $H[y_n] \leftarrow H[y_n] + 1$ ;  
    if  $y_n \leq y_c$  then  
       $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
  
  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
```

FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA



- Now the frequency values replace the objective values in the selection decisions.

```
procedure (1 + 1) EA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ )  
  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$ ;  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$ ;  
    if  $y_n \leq y_c$  then  $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
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    if  $H[y_n] \leq H[y_c]$  then  
       $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
  
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```

FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA



- Since we may now lose the best-so-far solution, we need to track it in additional variables.

```
procedure (1 + 1) EA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ )  
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    if  $y_n \leq y_c$  then  $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
```

```
procedure (1 + 1) FEA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{N}$ )  
   $H \leftarrow (0, 0, \dots, 0)$ ;  
  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$ ;  
   $x_B \leftarrow x_c$ ;  $y_B \leftarrow y_c$ ;  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$ ;  
     $H[y_c] \leftarrow H[y_c] + 1$ ;  $H[y_n] \leftarrow H[y_n] + 1$ ;  
    if  $H[y_n] \leq H[y_c]$  then  
       $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
  
  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
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    if  $y_n \leq y_c$  then  $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
```

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procedure (1 + 1) FEA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{N}$ )  
   $H \leftarrow (0, 0, \dots, 0)$ ;  
  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$ ;  
   $x_B \leftarrow x_c$ ;  $y_B \leftarrow y_c$ ;  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$ ;  
     $H[y_c] \leftarrow H[y_c] + 1$ ;  $H[y_n] \leftarrow H[y_n] + 1$ ;  
    if  $H[y_n] \leq H[y_c]$  then  
       $x_c \leftarrow x_n$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow y_n$ ;  
      if  $y_c < y_B$  then  $x_B \leftarrow x_c$ ;  $y_B \leftarrow y_c$ ;  
  return  $x_c, y_c$ 
```

FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA



- Since we may now lose the best-so-far solution, we need to track it in additional variables.
- ... which are then the return values of the (1 + 1) FEA.

```
procedure (1 + 1) EA( $f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ )  
  randomly sample  $x_c$  from  $\mathbb{X}$ ;  $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$ ;  
  while  $\neg$  terminate do  
     $x_n \leftarrow \text{move}(x_c)$ ;  $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$ ;  
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FFA: What does this do?



- The rating $H[f(x)]$ of a solution x depends only on how often solutions x' with $f(x') = f(x)$ have previously been seen in the optimization process.

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- Solutions with better objective values are no longer preferred over such with worse objective value.
- Instead, solutions with less-frequent objective values are preferred.
- Algorithms using FFA are invariant under all injective transformations of the objective function value.
- They are less likely to get stuck at local optima, which is a problem for, e.g., the $(1 + 1)$ EA.



Our Results



Frequency Fitness Assignment

Thomas Weise, *Member, IEEE*, Mingxu Wan, Pu Wang, *Member, IEEE*, Ke Tang, *Senior Member, IEEE*, Alexandre Devert, and Xin Yao, *Fellow, IEEE*

Abstract—Metaheuristic optimization procedures such as evolutionary algorithms are usually driven by an objective function that rates the quality of a candidate solution. However, it is not clear in practice whether an objective function adequately rewards intermediate solutions on the path to the global optimum and it may exhibit deceptiveness, epistasis, neutrality, ruggedness, and a lack of causality. In this paper, we introduce the frequency fitness II , subject to minimization, which rates how often solutions with the same objective value have been discovered so far. The ideas behind this method are that good solutions are difficult to find and that if an algorithm gets stuck at a local optimum, the frequency of the objective values of the surrounding solutions will increase over time, which will eventually allow it to leave that region again. We substitute a frequency fitness assignment process (FFA) for the objective function into several different optimization algorithms. We conduct a comprehensive set of experiments: the synthesis of algorithms with genetic programming (GP), the solution of MAX-SAT problems with genetic algorithms, classification with Memetic Genetic Programming, and numerical optimization with a (1+1) Evolution Strategy, to verify the utility of FFA. Given that they have no access to the original objective function at all, it is surprising that for some problems (e.g., the algorithm synthesis task) the FFA-based algorithm variants perform significantly better. However, this cannot be guaranteed for all tested problems. Thus, we also analyze scenarios where algorithms using FFA do not perform better or perform even worse than with the original objective functions.

Index Terms—Combinatorial optimization, diversity, fitness assignment, frequency, genetic programming (GP), numerical optimization.

I. INTRODUCTION

SINGLE-OBJECTIVE optimization is a process with the goal of finding (in all) i.e., (all) solutions x

from within a space $\mathcal{X}$ of possible solutions. An objective function f serves as quality measure guiding the search. Black-box metaheuristic approaches are methods that only require such an objective function and search operations to solve an optimization problem without any further insight into their structure. The most prominent family of these methods are evolutionary algorithms, which have wide applications ranging from engineering, planning and scheduling, numerical optimization, to even program synthesis.

Most metaheuristic optimization methods start with a randomly generated set of candidate solutions. New points in the search space are derived by modifying or combining promising existing solutions. Promising here means having a better objective value than the other points visited so far, maybe combined with some considerations about diversity. The rationale is that in the ideal case, solutions that have better objective values should be closer to the global optimum or, at least, may have even better solutions in their vicinity.

The principle of tending to choose areas of the solution space for sampling where points with better objective values have previously been discovered is one of the most universally applied ideas in black-box optimization. Lehman and Stanley [1] argued that increasing fitness does not always reveal the best path through the search space. Building on their work, we believe that there is at least one other fundamental principle inherent to non-trivial optimization problems: be exploited to solve them: good solutions (and hence objective values) are hard to find.

If a search or optimization process is stuck in a local optimum, the frequency of the objective values of the surrounding solutions will increase over time, which will eventually allow it to leave that region again.

Frequency Fitness

Thomas Weise, Member, IEEE, Mingxu Wan, Pu Wang, Member, IEEE, Alexandre Devert, and Xin Yao

Abstract—Metaheuristic optimization procedures such as evolutionary algorithms are usually driven by an objective function that rates the quality of a candidate solution. However, it is not clear in practice whether an objective function adequately rewards intermediate solutions on the path to the global optimum and it may exhibit deceptiveness, epistasis, neutrality, ruggedness, and a lack of causality. In this paper, we introduce the frequency fitness ff , subject to minimization, which rates how often solutions with the same objective value have been discovered so far. The ideas behind this method are that good solutions are difficult to find and that if an algorithm gets stuck at a local optimum, the frequency of the objective values of the surrounding solutions will increase over time, which will eventually allow it to leave that region again. We substitute a frequency fitness assignment process (FFA) for the objective function into several different optimization algorithms. We conduct a comprehensive set of experiments: the synthesis of algorithms with genetic programming (GP), the solution of MAX-SAT problems with genetic algorithms, classification with Memetic Genetic Programming, and numerical optimization with a (1+1) Evolution Strategy, to verify the utility of FFA. Given that they have no access to the original objective function at all, it is surprising that for some problems (e.g., the algorithm synthesis task) the FFA-based algorithm variants perform significantly better. However, this cannot be guaranteed for all tested problems. Thus, we also analyze scenarios where algorithms using FFA do not perform better or perform even worse than with the original objective functions.

Index Terms—Combinatorial optimization, diversity, fitness assignment, frequency, genetic programming (GP), numerical optimization.

I. INTRODUCTION

SINGLE-OBJECTIVE optimization is a process with the goal of finding the best solution (i.e., the global optimum) for a given problem. In this process, the quality of a candidate solution is measured by an objective function. The objective function is a mapping from the search space to the real numbers, where lower values indicate better solutions. The objective function is the only feedback that the optimization algorithm receives about the quality of its solutions. In this paper, we introduce a new fitness assignment method, the frequency fitness assignment (FFA), which is designed to improve the performance of evolutionary algorithms in solving single-objective optimization problems. The FFA method is based on the idea that the frequency of finding solutions with the same objective value is a good indicator of the difficulty of finding such solutions. If a solution is found frequently, it is likely that the search space is easy to explore, and the algorithm can quickly find better solutions. Conversely, if a solution is found infrequently, it is likely that the search space is difficult to explore, and the algorithm may get stuck in a local optimum. By using the frequency of finding solutions as a fitness measure, the FFA method can guide the search process towards more difficult-to-find solutions, which can help the algorithm escape local optima and find better solutions. The FFA method is implemented by assigning a frequency fitness value to each solution, which is the inverse of the number of times that solution has been found so far. The frequency fitness value is then used to replace the original objective function value in the fitness evaluation step of the optimization algorithm. This way, the algorithm is guided to search for solutions that have not been found frequently, which can help it escape local optima and find better solutions. The FFA method is evaluated on several benchmark single-objective optimization problems, and the results show that it can significantly improve the performance of several evolutionary algorithms, especially in problems where the search space is difficult to explore. The FFA method is a simple and effective fitness assignment method that can be used to improve the performance of evolutionary algorithms in solving single-objective optimization problems.

Frequency Fitness Assignment: Making Optimization Algorithms Invariant Under Bijective Transformations of the Objective Function Value

Thomas Weise[✉], Member, IEEE, Zhize Wu, Xinlu Li, and Yan Chen

Abstract—Under frequency fitness assignment (FFA), the fitness corresponding to an objective value is its encounter frequency in fitness assignment steps and is subject to minimization. FFA renders optimization processes invariant under bijective transformations of the objective function value. On TwoMax, Jump, and Trap functions of dimension s , the classical (1+1)-EA with standard mutation at rate $1/s$ can have expected runtimes exponential in s . In our experiments, a (1+1)-FEA, the same algorithm but using FFA, exhibits mean runtimes that seem to scale as s^2 in s . Since Jump and Trap are bijective transformations of OneMax, it behaves identical on all three. On OneMax, LeadingOnes, and Plateau problems, it seems to be slower than the (1+1)-EA by a factor linear in s . The (1+1)-FEA performs much better than the (1+1)-EA on W-Model and MaxSat instances. We further verify the bijection invariance by applying the Md5 checksum computation as transformation to some of the above problems and yield the same behaviors. Finally, we show that FFA can improve the performance of a memetic algorithm for job shop scheduling.

Index Terms—(1+1)-EA, evolutionary algorithm (EA), fitness assignment (and), job shop scheduling (JSS), memetic algorithm (MA), mutation, OneMax, Plateau, TwoMax, W-Model, MaxSat, Md5 checksum, bijection invariance, frequency fitness assignment (FFA), frequency fitness value, encounter frequency, fitness assignment steps, objective function value, bijective transformation, minimization, optimization process, search space, local optimum, global optimum, difficulty of finding solutions, frequency of finding solutions, frequency fitness value, inverse of the number of times that solution has been found so far, frequency fitness value, encounter frequency, fitness assignment steps, objective function value, bijective transformation, minimization, optimization process, search space, local optimum, global optimum, difficulty of finding solutions, frequency of finding solutions, frequency fitness value, inverse of the number of times that solution has been found so far.

which are then the basis for selection. Frequency fitness assignment (FFA) [1], [2] was developed to enable algorithms to escape from local optima. In FFA, the fitness corresponding to an objective value is its encounter frequency so far in fitness assignment steps and is subject to minimization. As we discuss in detail in Section II, FFA turns a static optimization problem into a dynamic one where objective values that are often encountered will receive worse and worse fitness.

In this article, we uncover a so-far unexplored property of FFA: it is invariant under any bijective transformation of the objective function values. This is the strongest invariance known to us and encompasses all order-preserving mappings. Other examples for bijective transformations include the negation, permutation, or even encryption of the objective values. According to [3], invariance extends performance observed on a single function to an entire class of functions, but is, it generalizes from classical optimization to the more general class of dynamic optimization problems. This, it hopefully helps to understand the success of FFA in solving difficult optimization problems.



Frequency Fitness

Thomas Weise, Member, IEEE, Mingxu Wan, Pu Wang, Mengjiao Wang, Alexandre Devert, and Xin Yao

Abstract—Metaheuristic optimization procedures such as evolutionary algorithms are usually driven by an objective function that rates the quality of a candidate solution. However, it is not clear in practice whether an objective function adequately rewards intermediate solutions on the path to the global optimum and may exhibit deceptiveness, epistasis, neutrality, ruggedness, and a lack of causality. In this paper, we introduce the frequency fitness FF , subject to minimization, which rates how often solutions with the same objective value have been discovered so far. The ideas behind this method are that good solutions are difficult to find and that if an algorithm gets stuck at a local optimum, the frequency of the objective values of the surrounding solutions will increase over time, which will eventually allow it to leave that region again. We substitute a frequency fitness assignment process (FFA) for the objective function into several different optimization algorithms. We conduct a comprehensive set of experiments: the synthesis of algorithms with genetic programming (GP), the solution of MAX-SAT problems with genetic algorithms, classification with Memetic Genetic Programming, and numerical optimization with a (1+1) Evolution Strategy, to verify the utility of FFA. Given that they have no access to the original objective function at all, it is surprising that for some problems (e.g., the algorithm synthesis task) the FFA-based algorithm variants perform significantly better. However, this cannot be guaranteed for all tested problems. Thus, we also analyze scenarios where algorithms using FFA do not perform better or perform even worse than with the original objective functions.

Index Terms—Combinatorial optimization, diversity, fitness assignment, frequency, genetic programming (GP), numerical optimization.

I. INTRODUCTION

SINGLE-OBJECTIVE optimization is a process with the goal of finding the best solution (i.e., the global optimum) among all possible solutions. In this process, the quality of a candidate solution is measured by an objective function. The objective function is a scalar value that represents the fitness of a candidate solution. The fitness function is a scalar value that represents the fitness of a candidate solution. The fitness function is a scalar value that represents the fitness of a candidate solution.

Frequency Fitness Assignment Method Optimization Algorithm Bijective Transformation Objective Function

Thomas Weise[✉], Member, IEEE, Zhihe Wu, Xinlu Li, Yan Chen, and Jörg Lässig

Abstract—Under frequency fitness assignment (FFA), the fitness corresponding to an objective value is its encounter frequency in fitness assignment steps and is subject to minimization. FFA renders optimization processes invariant under bijective transformations of the objective function value. On TwoMax, Jump, and Trap functions of dimension s , the classical (1+1)-EA with standard mutation at rate $1/s$ can have expected runtimes exponential in s . In our experiments, a (1+1)-FFEA, the same algorithm but using FFA, exhibits mean runtimes that seem to scale as s^2 in s . Since Jump and Trap are bijective transformations of OneMax, it behaves identical on all three. On OneMax, LeadingOnes, and Plateau problems, it seems to be slower than the (1+1)-EA by a factor linear in s . The (1+1)-FFEA performs much better than the (1+1)-EA on W-Model and MaxSat instances. We further verify the bijection invariance by applying the Md5 checksum computation as transformation to some of the above problems and yield the same behaviors. Finally, we show that FFA can improve the performance of a memetic algorithm for job shop scheduling.

Index Terms—(1+1)-EA, evolutionary algorithm (EA), fitness assignment (FFA), frequency fitness assignment (FFA), job shop scheduling, leading ones, maxsat, mutation, one max, plateau, trap, two max, w-model benchmark.

Frequency Fitness Assignment: Optimization Without Bias for Good Solutions Can Be Efficient

Thomas Weise[✉], Zhihe Wu, Xinlu Li, Yan Chen, and Jörg Lässig

Abstract—A fitness assignment process transforms the features (such as the objective value) of a candidate solution to a scalar fitness, which then is the basis for selection. Under frequency fitness assignment (FFA), the fitness corresponding to an objective value is its encounter frequency in selection steps and is subject to minimization. FFA creates algorithms that are not biased toward better solutions and are invariant under all injective transformations of the objective function value. We investigate the impact of FFA on the performance of two theory inspired, state-of-the-art evolutionary algorithms, the Greedy (2+1) GA and the self-adjusting (1+ λ , 1) GA. FFA improves their performance significantly on some problems that are hard for them. In our experiments, one FFA-based algorithm exhibited mean runtimes that appear to be polynomial on the theory-based benchmark problems in our study, including traps, jumps, and plateaus. We propose two hybrid approaches that use both direct and FFA-based optimization and find that they perform well. All FFA-based algorithms also perform better on satisfiability problems than any of the pure algorithm variants.

Index Terms—Evolutionary algorithm (EA), FFA, frequency fitness assignment (FFA), Ising problems, jump problems, linear harmonic functions, MaxSat problem, N-queens problem, OneMax, Plateau problems, satisfiability, Trap function, TwoMax, W-model benchmark.

fitness assignment (FFA), the fitness of a candidate solution is the absolute encounter frequency of its objective value so far during the optimization process [1]. Being subject to minimization, FFA drives the search away from already-discovered objective values and toward solutions with new qualities.

FFA breaks with one of the most fundamental concepts of heuristic optimization: FFA-based algorithms are not biased toward better solutions [2], i.e., they do not prefer better solutions over worse ones. They also are invariant under all injective transformations of the objective function value, which is the strongest invariance property of any nontrivial single-objective optimization algorithm [3].¹ Only random sampling, random walks, and exhaustive enumeration have similar properties and neither of them is considered to be an efficient optimization method.

One would expect that this comes at a significant performance penalty. Yet, FFA performed well in Genetic Programming tasks with their often rugged, deceptive, and highly epistatic landscapes [1], [4] and on a benchmark problem simulating such landscapes [5]. While the (1+1) EA has exponential expected runtime on problems, such as Jump TwoMax and Trap, the (1+1) FFA, the same algorithm using FFA, exhibits mean runtimes that are linear in s [3].

INTRODUCTION

IT IS WELL KNOWN that many optimization problems are NP-hard. In this paper, we focus on the frequency fitness assignment (FFA) method, which is a simple and efficient way to assign fitness values to candidate solutions. The FFA method is based on the idea of frequency fitness assignment, which is a simple and efficient way to assign fitness values to candidate solutions. The FFA method is based on the idea of frequency fitness assignment, which is a simple and efficient way to assign fitness values to candidate solutions.

Discrete Benchmark Functions



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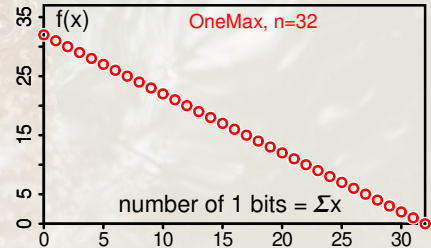


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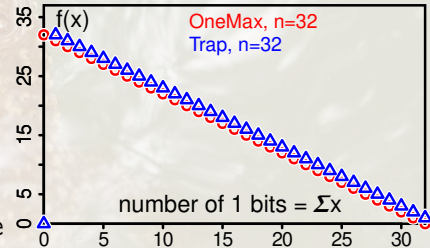
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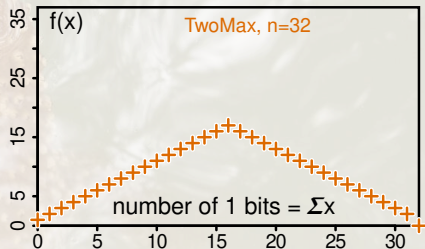
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- It needs $\Theta(n^n)$ on traps⁶¹, where the optimum and the worst solution are exchanged compared to OneMax, as well as on TwoMax^{76,192}, which has one local and one global optimum.



Discrete Benchmark Functions

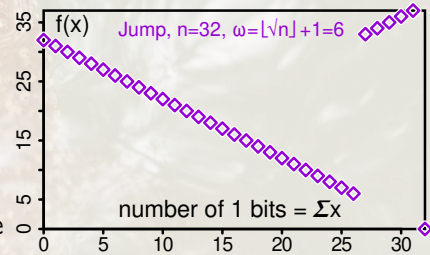


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- The $(1 + 1)$ EA can easily solve the OneMax problem, where the goal is to find a bit string of all 1s¹⁵⁰.
- It needs $\Theta(n^n)$ on traps⁶¹, where the optimum and the worst solution are exchanged compared to OneMax, as well as on TwoMax^{76,192}, which has one local and one global optimum.
- The $(1 + 1)$ FEA solves all three problems in polynomial time!

Discrete Benchmark Functions



- Discrete optimization algorithms work on bit strings of length n as search space and use only the objective values of the solutions they sample to solve a problem.
- They are usually tested on a variety of benchmark problems.
- We plug FFA into the $(1 + 1)$ EA and obtain the $(1 + 1)$ FEA.
- The $(1 + 1)$ EA can easily solve the OneMax problem, where the goal is to find a bit string of all 1s¹⁵⁰.
- It needs $\Theta(n^n)$ on traps⁶¹, where the optimum and the worst solution are exchanged compared to OneMax, as well as on TwoMax^{76,192}, which has one local and one global optimum.
- The $(1 + 1)$ FEA solves all three problems in polynomial time as well as the Jump problem, where the $(1 + 1)$ EA also needs exponential runtime!



Maximum Satisfiability Problem



- FFA on the Maximum Satisfiability (MaxSAT) Problem, one of the most famous discrete optimization problems [205, 207, 208].

Maximum Satisfiability Problem



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From Table I, we can see that **the highest number of failed runs at scale $s = 250$ of any algorithm using FFA is lower than the lowest number of failed runs of any pure algorithm at $s = 50$.** From Table II, we find that no FFA-based algorithm has a higher ERT at scale $s = 250$ than its pure variant on $s = 50$. On the scales $s \leq 75$, the FFA-based algorithms have a mean runtime which is between three and four orders of magnitude smaller than the ERT of the pure algorithms.

- Snippet of page 10 of [208] (copyright IEEE).
- Several different EAs with and without FFA

Traveling Salesperson Problem



- FFA on the Traveling Salesperson Problem (TSP): [125–127].

Traveling Salesperson Problem

- FFA on the Traveling Salesperson Problem (TSP): [125–127].
- Snippet of page 12 of [125] (copyright Springer).
- $(1 + 1)$ EA, $(1 + 1)$ FEA, Simulated Annealing (SA) w/o FFA, hybrids

In this work, we explored both the EA and SA on 56 symmetric instances from the benchmark set TSPLib (Reinelt 1991, 1995). The EA is unsuitable for this problem, but SA can find the optimum on many small and mid-sized instances. We then plug FFA into both algorithms and obtain the FEA and the FSA, respectively, which both exhibit very similar performance. **The FEA solves 27 of the instances in all of its runs, which SA can only achieve for 19 instances.** Plugging FFA into either the EA or SA thus substantially improved the number of runs in which the algorithms can find the optimum, however, both FFA-based variants suffer when the number of unique objective values is high.

• • •

Both types of **hybridization** methods significantly improve the average result quality compared to both the objective-guided and FFA-based FEA variants. **The SAFEA_A discovers the optimal solutions in more runs than any other algorithm setup in our study.** It also finds the optimum most often in most instances and delivers the best approximation quality on most instances, compared to the other algorithms.

Quadratic Assignment Problem



- FFA on the Quadratic Assignment Problem (QAP): [36, 188].

Quadratic Assignment Problem

- FFA on the Quadratic Assignment Problem (QAP): [36, 188].
- Snippet of page 7 of [36] (copyright SciTePress).
- RLS w/o FFA

We find that the **FFA-based** randomized local search **FRLS does not just find better solutions than the objective-guided RLS algorithm on the vast majority of the QAPLIB instances**, it also keeps improving its current best solution for the complete computational budget of 10^8 FEs that we assigned to the runs. With this budget, **it can discover the optimal solutions of over 58% of the QAPLIB instances**. Had we assigned a larger budget – (Liang et al., 2022; Liang et al., 2024; Weise et al., 2021b; Weise et al., 2023) use 10^{10} FEs – we would likely have seen even more instances solved.

We furthermore confirm the remarkable ability of FFA to discover very diverse solutions (at least from the perspective of the objective function). It is known that on the QAP, many solutions tend to have the same objective values (Tayarani-N. and Prügell-Bennett, 2015). Yet, on some of the instances, more than half of the objective values discovered by FRLS were unique.

Job Shop Scheduling Problem



- FFA on the Job Shop Scheduling Problem (JSSP) Problem: [45, 202, 207].

Job Shop Scheduling Problem



- FFA on the Job Shop Scheduling Problem (JSSP) Problem: [45, 202, 207].

The **end result quality delivered by (1+1)-FEA is better in average on the abz*, ft*, la*, orb*, and yn4* instance sets, both in terms of *best* and *mean*.** On swv*, the average for *mean* is better for (1+1)-FEA, while (1+1)-EA has a slight lead in *best*. The (1+1)-EA performs better on the dmμ* and ta* instances. Since these two sets are larger (holding 160 out of the 242 instances), the (1+1)-EA comes out ahead in the overall averages, but with no more than a 1.5% advantage.

- Snippet of page 10 of [202] (copyright ACM).

Algorithm Synthesis and Genetic Programming



- FFA for algorithm synthesis and Genetic Programming (GP): [204, 205].

Algorithm Synthesis and Genetic Programming



- FFA for algorithm synthesis and Genetic Programming (GP): [204, 205].

Fourth, we were able to confirm with great significance that **FFA** has a tremendous positive impact on the performance of GP, as it **can increase the success rate by 40%**.

- Snippet of page 7 of [204] (copyright IEEE).



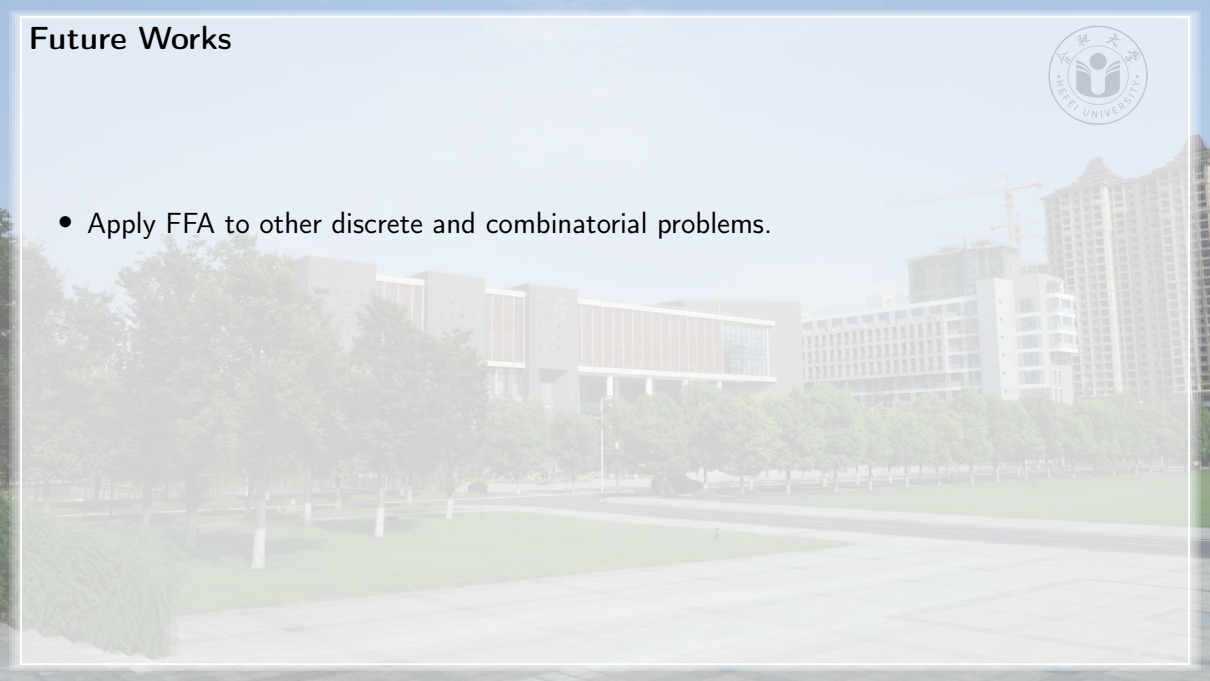
Future Works



Future Works



- Apply FFA to other discrete and combinatorial problems.



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- Plug FFA into more optimization algorithms.

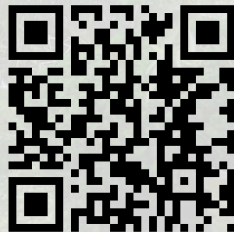
Future Works



- Apply FFA to other discrete and combinatorial problems:
 1. Where can FFA improve the solution quality?
 2. Where can it not do that?
 3. Why?
- Plug FFA into more optimization algorithms.
- Combine “traditional” and FFA-based optimization, i.e., create hybrid algorithms, to reap the best of both worlds.



Summary



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 2. on the Traveling Tournament Problem (TTP), we also got surprisingly good results with RLS²¹³ and SA.



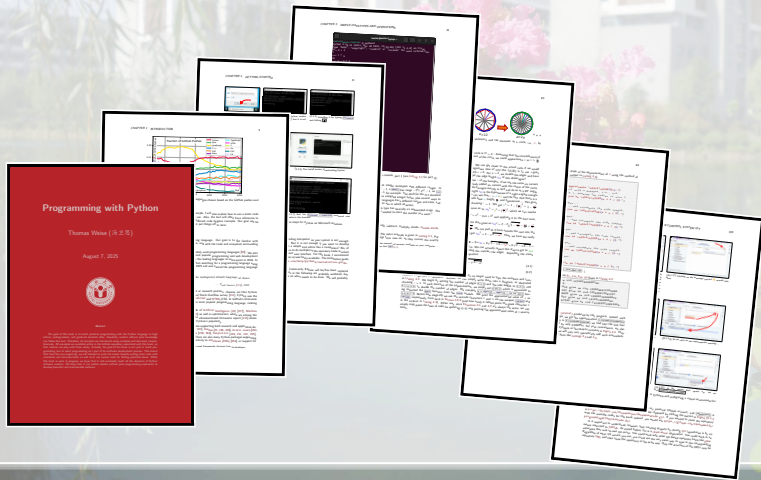
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Programming with Python



We have a freely available course book on *Programming with Python* at <https://thomasweise.github.io/programmingWithPython>, with focus on practical software development using the Python ecosystem of tools²⁰⁰.



Databases



We have a freely available course book on *Databases* at <https://thomasweise.github.io/databases>, with actual practical examples using a real database management system (DBMS)¹⁹⁶.



Metaheuristic Optimization in Python: moptipy



We offer moptipy²⁰⁶, a mature open source Python package for metaheuristic optimization, which implements several algorithms, can run self-documenting experiments in parallel and in a distributed fashion, and offers statistical evaluation tools.

moptipy: Metaheuristic Optimization in Python

- Index
- Module Index
- Search Page

1. Introduction

moptipy is a library with implementations of metaheuristic optimization methods in Python 3.12 that also offers an environment for replicable experiments. The framework, `Experiment`, and the library design are accompanied by the book *Optimization Algorithms*. The library is structured with performance, ease-of-use, and generality in mind, but also based on an educational and research perspective. It is therefore hopefully suitable for practical industrial applications, scientific research, and for students who are just entering the field of metaheuristic optimization.

Metaheuristic optimization algorithms are methods for solving hard problems. moptipy provides an API, several algorithm implementations, as well as *experiment execution and evaluation* facilities for metaheuristics.

A metaheuristic algorithm can be a black-box method, which can solve problems without deeper knowledge about their nature. Such a black-box algorithm only requires methods to *create* and *modify* points in the search space and to *evaluate their quality*. With these operations, it will try to discover better solutions step-by-step. Black-box metaheuristics are very general and can be adapted to almost any optimization problem. They allow us also to do

Progress plots are implemented in the module `moptipy.evaluation.plot_progress`.





谢谢你们！
Thank you!
Vielen Dank!



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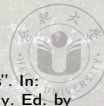
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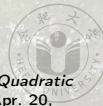
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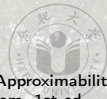
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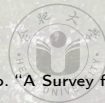
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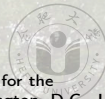
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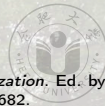
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Glossary I



- (1 + 1) EA** The (1 + 1) EA is a local search algorithm that retains the best solution x_c discovered so far during the search^{33,61}. In each step, it applies a unary search operator to this best-so-far solution x_c and derives a new solution x_n . If the new solution x_n is *better or equally good* when compared with x_c , i.e., not worse, then it replaces it, i.e., is stored as the new x_c . If the search space are bit strings of length n , then the (1 + 1) EA uses a unary search operator that flips each bit independently with probability m/n , where usually $m = 1$. This operator is the main difference to randomized local search (RLS). The (1 + 1) EA is a special case of the $(\mu + \lambda)$ evolutionary algorithm $((\mu + \lambda)$ EA) where $\mu = \lambda = 1$.
- (1 + 1) FEA** The (1 + 1) EA with FFA plugged in^{207,208,217}. On the discrete bit-string domains, this algorithm has a very specific structure: Its unary search operator flips each bit with probability $1/n$, where n is the dimension of the search space, distinguishing it from the unary operator in FRLS which flips exactly one bit. On other domains, such as permutations, the term is used synonymously with FRLS.
- $(\mu + \lambda)$ EA** The $(\mu + \lambda)$ EA is an evolutionary algorithm (EA) where, in each generation, λ offspring solutions are generated from the current population of μ parent solutions. The offspring and parent populations are merged, yielding $\mu + \lambda$ solutions, from which then the best μ solutions are retained to form the parent population of the next generation. If the search space is the bit strings of length n , then this algorithm usually applies a mutation operator flipping each bit independently with probability $1/n$.
- BinInt** The *Binary Integer Problem* is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{187,217}. It is very similar to OneMax: It tries to maximize the number of 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n . Different from OneMax, where each bit has the same weight in the objective function, the bits of BinInt have a exponentially increasing weight: The bit string is treated as a binary-encoded integer whose value should be maximized. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = 2^n - 1 - \sum_{i=1}^n 2^{i-1} \cdot x_i$. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. It is fully separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately.
- LinHarm** The Linear Harmonic Function is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{55,61,217}. It is very similar to OneMax: It tries to maximize the number of 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n . Different from OneMax, where each bit has the same weight in the objective function, the bits of LinHarm have a linear increasing weight. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = \frac{1}{2}n(n+1) - \sum_{i=1}^n i \cdot x_i$. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. It is fully separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately. The (1 + 1) EA can solve this problem with an expected runtime in $\Theta(n \ln n)$ ^{55,61}.

Glossary II



2BP In the two-dimensional Bin Packing Problem (BP), the goal is to pack rectangles into rectangular bins without overlap and such that their edges are parallel to the edges of the bins^{100,130,132}. The 2BP is strongly $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard¹³². The variants of this problem include the 2BP|O|F, 2BP|R|F, 2BP|O|G, and 2BP|R|G^{131,132}. Different objective function for the 2BP|O|F and 2BP|R|F are presented in²¹⁹. 2BPs have many practical applications, including cutting (wood, glass)¹³², packing (transportation, warehouse)¹³², and newspaper page layout¹⁸⁰.

2BP|O|F In the oriented 2BP with free cuts, the rectangles to pack have fixed orientations, i.e., cannot be rotated, but can otherwise be arranged freely^{131,132,140,220}. Permutation-based search spaces can be used for this problem by using the Improved Bottom Left (IBL) encoding. The SOTA for this problem comprises^{20,25,39,84,157,220}.

2BP|O|G In the oriented 2BP with guillotine cuts, the rectangles to pack have fixed orientations, i.e., cannot be rotated, and must be arranged such that they can be extracted by edge-to-edge cuts^{131,132}.

2BP|R|F In this variant of the 2BP with free cuts, the rectangles to pack can be rotated by 90° if need be and can freely be arranged^{17,131,132,219,220}. Besides packing and cutting, this problem also occurs in scheduling and build formation in additive manufacturing^{124,161}. The almost-squares-in-almost-squares (Asqas) problem¹⁹¹ is also a 2BP|R|F. Search spaces based on signed permutations can be used for this problem by using the IBL encoding. The SOTA for this problem comprises^{20,39,84,219,220}.

2BP|R|G In this variant of the 2BP with guillotine cuts, the rectangles to pack can be rotated by 90° if need be, but must be arranged such that they can be extracted by edge-to-edge cuts^{131,132}.

ACO *Ant Colony Optimization* is a nature-inspired optimization method for combinatorial problems where solutions are generated by “ants” that move from node to node in a graph choosing edges based on (1) the simulated pheromone on the edges and (2) a per-edge heuristic value^{57–59}. If an ant produced a good solution, “pheromone” is distributed over the edges it visited, making it more likely to be re-visited by other ants.

AI Artificial Intelligence, see, e.g.,¹⁷¹

Glossary III



Asqas An “almost-square” be a rectangle with size $i \times (i + 1)$ with $i \in \mathbb{N}_1$. The *almost-squares-in-almost-squares* problem¹⁹¹ is a special case of the 2BP|R|F. Here, almost-square rectangles of sizes $1 \times 2, 2 \times 3, \dots, n \times (n + 1)$ must be placed into an almost-square bin without waste. This requires that there exists a natural number $p \in \mathbb{N}_1$ such that $p(p + 1) = \sum_{i=1}^n i(i + 1)$ ¹⁹¹. There are exactly five Asqas instances¹⁹¹, namely with bin sizes 1×2 for $n = 1, p = 1, 5 \times 4$ for $n = 3, p = 4, 15 \times 16$ for $n = 8, p = 15, 55 \times 56$ for $n = 20, p = 55$, and 119×120 for $n = 34, p = 119$.

ATSP The general case for TSPs are *asymmetric Traveling Salesperson Problems*, where the $n \times n$ distance matrix A does not need to be symmetric. In other words, it is possible that $\exists a, b \in 1..n$ with $A[a, b] \neq A[b, a]$. Notice that while such index tuple may exist, this is not always or necessarily the case. In this case, one may consider the STSP as a special case of the ATSP, while ATSPs may be considered as synonymous to TSPs.

BP The *Bin Packing Problem*^{63,173} is one of the classical problems from Operations Research (OR). The goal is to pack a set of objects into containers, using as few containers as possible. Different flavors of BPs can be distinguished, e.g., by the number of dimensions^{48,130} that the objects and containers have (see, e.g., the 2BP), and/or whether the objects can be rotated²²⁰, as well as other constraints and limitations. Both the one- and two-dimensional BP are strongly $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard¹³².

BRKGA The *Biased Random Key Genetic Algorithm* is a EA with a continuous search space $\mathbb{X} \subset [0, 1]^n$ and a decoding function γ translating this space to something else and biased, uniform, and elitist mating strategies^{86,135}. The *bias* comes from the fact that one of the parents used for the binary operation is biased to be of higher fitness than the other parent⁸⁶. Often, γ is the Random Keys encoding^{12,13} procedure translating $\mathbb{X}$ to permutations of the first n natural numbers⁸⁵. Sometimes, it is actually a MA further refining the translation result with a local search (LS)⁸⁵. Sometimes the permutations are then further translated to more complex data structures, such as Gantt charts for the JSSP⁸⁵, or packing plans for 2BP 3D packing⁸⁴.

C is a programming language, which is very successful in system programming situations^{52,165,199}.

Concorde is an exact solver for the TSP^{4,41,42}, which could even solve the largest instance of TSPLib (with 85 900 cities) to optimality.

DB A *database* is an organized collection of structured information or data, typically stored electronically in a computer system. Databases are discussed in our book *Databases*¹⁹⁶.

Glossary IV



- DBMS** A *database management system* is the software layer located between the user or application and the database (DB). The DBMS allows the user/application to create, read, write, update, delete, and otherwise manipulate the data in the DB ²¹⁵.
- EA** An *evolutionary algorithm* is a metaheuristic optimization method that maintains a population of candidate solutions, which undergo selection (where better solutions are chosen with higher probability) and reproduction (where mutation and recombination create a new candidate solution from one or two existing ones, respectively) ^{7,197}.
- FFA** *Frequency Fitness Assignment* (中文: 频率适应度分配) is a algorithm plugin for optimization methods applied to discrete or combinatorial problems with not-too-many different possible objective values ^{205,207,208}. It replaces the objective values in all comparisons with their absolute encounter frequency so far during the search. FFA has successfully been applied to the MaxSAT ^{207,208}, the TSP ^{125,126}, and the QAP ^{38,188}, amongst others. Its properties have been intensely researched on discrete benchmark functions such as OneMax, LeadingOnes, Trap, TwoMax, Jump, and Plateau ^{207,208,217}. The most common realizations of FFA so far are the (1 + 1) FEA and FRLS.
- FSSP** The *Flow Shop Scheduling Problem* is a variant of a JSSP where all products go through the same sequence of machines ^{88,109}.
- Gantt chart** Gantt charts are two-dimensional diagrams illustrating the steps of a process ^{111,211}. Their horizontal axis represents the time, the vertical axis represents work packages, machines, or workers. In the diagram area, bars located at certain vertical locations indicate that the work package, machine, or worker is processed or works at the time range covered by the bar as projected to the horizontal axis.
- GP** *Genetic Programming* ^{115,162,197,203} is the application of metaheuristic optimization, usually in form of an EAs, to a search space comprised of tree datastructures. These tree datastructures often represent programs or mathematical expressions.
- GRASP** A *Greedy Randomized Adaptive Search Procedure* is a metaheuristic where each cycle consists of two main components ^{67,69,70}: First, a starting point is generated using a heuristic method (as opposed to being randomly sampled). Then, a LS is applied to refine the solution. Then, another cycle starts and proceeds in the same way. The overall best solution is retained as result. Many examples for applications of GRASPs are listed in ⁷⁰. GRASP in combination with VND has been applied to the 2BP|O|F in ¹⁵⁷.

Glossary V



IBL The *improved bottom left* heuristic is a one-shot algorithm constructing a solution for 2BP¹²⁹. For the 2BP|O|F problem variant, the input of the IBL algorithm is a permutation of the first n natural numbers, each number identifying one rectangle to be packed. For the 2BP|R|F problem flavor, the permutation elements are signed, where a negative sign indicates a rotation by 90° ¹²⁹. In^{219,220} it is adapted to a multi-bin situation as follows: The algorithm iterates over the (potentially signed) permutation x and places the rectangles into the packing plan in the prescribed order. It first places the rectangle outside on top of the current bin b , with its bottom-right corner onto the top-right corner of the current bin b . It then moves the rectangle downwards and leftwards as far as possible, prioritizing the downward movement whenever possible. If the rectangle cannot be moved any further, it checks if it is completely contained in the bin b . If yes, it can remain there. Otherwise, a new bin is opened ($b \leftarrow b + 1$) and the rectangle is placed at its bottom-left corner. Once a new bin is opened, this bin is used for all further insertions. IBL is suitable as a decoding function γ inside an EA¹²⁹. Historically, it improves upon the BL algorithm¹⁰⁴: That algorithm cannot represent all possible optimal packings using a permutation, but the IBL can¹²⁹.

ILS An *iterated local search* is a variant of the LS which applies cycles of local search and perturbation¹⁸¹. First, an initial solution is generated and refined by the local search. Then the cycle begins: A perturbation, i.e., a large search move that likely destroys a good part of the solution, is applied. The resulting new solution is refined by local search. Then, an acceptance criterion decides whether we should use this or the previous solution to continue in the next cycle. ILS has successfully been applied to the QAP.

Ising Model The Ising models are benchmark problems for bit-string based black-box search^{55,71,72,217}. Here, a neighborhood is defined around each bit. The bit needs to have the same value as all bits in the neighborhood structure T . Thus, we try to achieve that all bits have the same value. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem family can be defined as $f(x, T) = \sum_{(i,j) \in T} |x_i - x_j|$, where T contains the index pairs of neighboring bits and is defined differently for the Ising model instances Ising 1D and Ising 2D. The problems are highly epistatic, as all variables interact with some other variables.

Ising 1D The 1D is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{55,72,217}. The bits are arranged in a one-dimensional ring and we try to minimize the number of bits that have different values than their neighbors. Hence, the neighborhood structure T is defined as $T_{1D} = \{(i + 1, (i + 1 \bmod n) + 1) \mid i \in [0..n - 1]\}$. The problems are highly epistatic, as all variables interact with some other variables. The $(1 + 1)$ EA has an expected runtime in $\mathcal{O}(n^3)$ on 1-Dimensional Ising Model (Ising 1D)⁷².

Glossary VI



Ising 2D The 2D is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{55,71,217}. The bits are arranged in a two-dimensional torus and we try to minimize the number of bits that have different values than their neighbors. Hence, the neighborhood structure $T = T_{2D}$ is defined as the set of all $\{(\alpha + \beta N, \gamma + \delta N)\}$ pairs with $\alpha, \beta, \gamma, \delta \in 0..N - 1$ and either $(\gamma = (\alpha + 1) \bmod N \text{ and } \delta = \beta)$ or $(\gamma = \alpha \text{ and } \delta = (\beta + 1) \bmod N)$ with $n = N^2$. The problems are highly epistatic, as all variables interact with some other variables. On a similar class of problems, the $(1 + 1)$ EA has an exponential expected runtime⁷¹.

Java is another very successful programming language, with roots in the C family of languages^{24,136}.

JSSP The *Job Shop Scheduling Problem*^{23,38,88,120} is one of the most prominent and well-studied scheduling tasks. In a JSSP instance, there are m machines and k jobs¹⁸². Each job must be processed once by each machine in a job-specific sequence and has a job-specific processing time on each machine. The goal is to find an assignment of jobs to machines that results in an overall shortest makespan, i.e., the schedule (Gantt chart) which can complete all the jobs in the shortest time. The JSSP is $\mathcal{NP}$ -complete^{35,119,120}. The 8 most common sets of JSSP benchmark instances are *abz*¹, *dmu*⁴⁹, *ft*⁷³, *la*¹²², *orb*⁵, *swv*¹⁷⁹, *ta*¹⁸², and *yn*²¹⁴. Their data can be found (sometimes partially) in several repositories, such as the OR-Library^{14,15},¹⁷⁵, and¹⁹⁸, the latter of which also contains many results from existing works. Encodings based on permutations with repetition are proposed in^{21,22,79,174} and used in²⁰⁷. The SOTA of the JSSP includes^{85,94,156,158,176,195,218}.

Jump The Jump problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{61,76,217}. Like the OneMax, it tries to maximize the number of 1 bits in a bit string of chosen length n . However, the solutions representing the last ω bits around the optimum to flip are deceptive, meaning that they are actually worse and getting worse than surrounding solutions. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is $n - \|x\|_1$ if $\|x\|_1 = n$ or $\|x\|_1 \leq n - \omega$ hold, and $\omega + \|x\|_1$ otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^n x_i$. This means that, the larger ω , the larger the deceptive basin around the optimum that an algorithm needs to cross. An $(1 + 1)$ EA will converge to the resulting local optimum and thus have an expected runtime of $\Theta(n^\omega + n \ln n)$ ⁶¹. In experiments, the $(1 + 1)$ FEA achieves polynomial runtime on Jump, seemingly in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ ^{207,208,217}.

Glossary VII



LABS *Low-Autocorrelation Binary Sequences* are bit strings of length n whose autocorrelation is as low as possible^{26-28,50,51,77,141,143,149,154,164}. This means that sub-sequences of any length $1 \leq k < n$ should ideally never repeat. The objective function $f : \{0, 1\}^n \mapsto \mathbb{N}_0$ represents the energy of a bit string x and is subject to minimization. We can define it as $f(x) = \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} \left(\sum_{i=0}^{n-1-k} s_i \cdot s_{i+k} \right)^2$ with $s_j = 2x_j - 1$. Such sequences are needed for communication engineering^{27,28,149}, cryptography^{50,149}, as well as modulation pulses in radar and sonar ranging¹⁵⁴. The LABS is $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard¹⁹⁰. The SOTA on LABS contains^{26,28,50,51,149}.

LeadingOnes The LeadingOnes problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{170,210,217}. It tries to maximize the number of *leading* 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n . The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = n - \sum_{i=1}^n \prod_{j=1}^i x_j$. Different from OneMax, the contribution to the objective value of the bit at index i thus depends on the state of all the bits *before* this index. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. Different from OneMax, it is not separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately. The expected runtime of $(1 + 1)$ EA on LeadingOnes is in $\Theta(n^2)$ ⁶¹. The average runtime $(1 + 1)$ FEA on LeadingOnes seems to be slower by factor proportional to n , i.e., seems to be in $\mathcal{O}(n^3)$ ²⁰⁷.

LK The *Lin-Kernighan* (LK) algorithm¹²⁸ is a SLS method for the TSP. The LK algorithm performs iterative k -opt moves, i.e., in each step, it constructs the two sets X and Y of k edges such that removing the edges in X from the current tour T and then adding the edges from Y to T results in a better tour. The LK algorithm is one of the most classical approaches to the TSP.

LKH The *Lin-Kernighan-Helsgaun* algorithm^{42,92,93} is a SLS method for the TSP based on the Lin-Kernighan (LK) algorithm¹²⁸. LKH-1 was proposed in⁹³ and LKH-2 in⁹². It holds the record in the *World TSP*⁴³ as of 2025.

LS A *local search* is an algorithm where a single “current” candidate solution is maintained and new solutions are selected from its neighborhood in each step. Most LSes are randomized, i.e., stochastic local search (SLS).

MA A *Memetic Algorithm* is an EA where each new solution is refined by a LS before it enters the population¹⁹⁷. As LS, we can use, e.g., RLS, but TS^{37,74} is maybe a better choice. Some SOTA algorithms in some domains may be classified as MAs, e.g., Lin-Kernighan Helsgaun (LKH) basically uses a population that is refined via a local search. MAs also worked well on the JSSP^{37,94} and the TSP⁷⁴.

Glossary VIII



- MaxSAT** The goal of satisfiability problems is to find an assignment for n Boolean variables that make a given Boolean formula $F : \{0, 1\}^n \mapsto \{0, 1\}$ become true. In the *Maximum Satisfiability* problem (MaxSAT)⁹⁵, F is given in conjunctive normal form, i.e., the variables appear either directly or negated in m “or” clauses, which are all combined into one “and.” The objective function $f(x)$, subject to minimization, computes the number of clauses which are false under the variable setting x . If $f(x) = 0$, then all clauses of F are true, which solves the problem. The MaxSAT problem is $\mathcal{NP}$ -complete⁴⁰ and exhibits low epistasis but deceptiveness¹⁶⁷, making it hard for local searches. Typical benchmark instances can be found in SATLIB, which contains smaller-scale instances, and the up-to-date MaxSAT Evaluation (MSE), providing SOTA benchmarks, algorithms, and results.
- metaheuristic** A *metaheuristic* is an optimization algorithm which performs a cycle of trial and error during which candidate solutions are sampled from the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$ and evaluated using an objective function $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ ^{82,197}. The results of the objective function are used to decide which solution is promising. The neighborhoods around promising solutions or similarly-structured solutions are then sampled in the next cycle. Prominent metaheuristics are SLSes, SA, TS, and EAs.
- moptipy** is the *Metaheuristic Optimization in Python* library²⁰⁶. It has been used in several different research works, including^{36,125–127,188,213,219,220}. Algorithms implemented by moptipy include EAs, (1 + 1) EA, RLS, SA, and the (1 + 1) FEA, amongst others. Learn more at <https://thomasweise.github.io/moptipy> and <https://thomasweise.github.io/moptipyapps>.
- MSE** The *MaxSAT Evaluation* is a regularly updated set of benchmark instances for the MaxSAT¹⁰¹. It also includes solver software and benchmark results¹⁹³.
- N-Queens** The N-Queens Problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{55,217}. The goal is to arrange N queens on an $N \times N$ chessboard so that none can attack the other. The search space has thus dimension $n = N^2$, with each bit standing for a field and encoding whether or not a queen is placed there. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is $N - (\sum_{i=1}^n x_i) - N \sum_{\xi} \max \{0, Q_{\xi}(x) - 1\}$ where $Q_{\xi}(x)$ is the number of queens in the horizontal, vertical, or diagonale ξ . The problem is quite epistatic.

Glossary IX



- OneMax** OneMax is the simplest possible benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{62,150,217}. The goal is to maximize the number of 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n . The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = n - \sum_{i=1}^n x_i$. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. It is fully separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately. The expected runtime of $(1 + 1)$ EA on OneMax is in $\Theta(n \ln n)$ ^{53,150}. The average runtime $(1 + 1)$ FEA on OneMax seems to be slower by factor proportional to n , i.e., seems to be in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ ²⁰⁷.
- OR** Operations Research (or Operational Research) is the application of sciences such as mathematics and computer science to the management and organization of systems, organizations, enterprises, factories, or projects. It encompasses the development and application of problem-solving methods and techniques (such as mathematical optimization, simulation, queueing theory and other stochastic models) with the goal to improve decision-making and efficiency⁴⁶.
- OR-Library** is a library of benchmark instances for various OR problems^{14,15} located at <https://people.brunel.ac.uk/~mastjjb/jeb/info.html>. It contains instances of the JSSP, 1D- and 2D-Packing, Knapsack, periodic TSPs, amongst others.
- Plateau** The Plateau problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{3,217}. It is structured exactly like Jump, but instead of being deceptive, the last ω bits to flip around the optimum are neutral. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is $n - \|x\|_1$ if $\|x\|_1 = n$ or $\|x\|_1 \leq n - \omega$ hold, and ω otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^n x_i$. This means that, the larger ω , the larger the neutral plane around the optimum that an algorithm needs to cross. An $(1 + 1)$ EA has an expected runtime of $\Theta(n^\omega)$ on plateaus³. The average runtime of the $(1 + 1)$ FEA on Plateaus is slower by a factor seemingly proportional in n .
- PostgreSQL** An open source object-relational DBMS^{68,153,163,186}. See <https://postgresql.org> for more information.
- Python** The Python programming language^{98,123,137,200}, i.e., what you will learn about in our book²⁰⁰. Learn more at <https://python.org>.

Glossary X



QAP The *Quadratic Assignment Problem* is an optimization problem where the goal is to assign a set of n facilities to a set of n locations^{30,36,114,133}. Such an assignment can be represented as a permutation x of the first n natural numbers, where x_i specifies the location where facility i should be placed. For each QAP instance, a distance matrix A is given, where $A[a, b]$ specifies the distance from location a to location b , as well as a flow matrix B , where $B[i, j]$ is the amount of material flowing (e.g., daily) from facility i to facility j . The objective function $f(x)$ then rates a permutation x as $f(x) = \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n A[x_i, x_j] * B[i, j]$. The QAP is $\mathcal{NP}$ -complete^{60,172} and even among this problem class, is considered as particularly hard for metaheuristics^{16,30,133,181}. The QAP has applications such as building layout^{44,65,116}, keyboard layout³², circuit design⁶⁶, wiring¹⁷⁸, and scheduling¹⁷⁷. Typical benchmark instances can be found in QAPLIB. SOTA algorithms for the QAP include^{16,74,142,147,184,185}.

QAPLIB is a library of 136 benchmark instances for the Quadratic Assignment Problem (QAP)^{29,31}, 28 of which have not yet been solved to optimality² (at least by 2023).

Random Keys encoding is a decoding procedure $\gamma : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{Y}$ that maps a continuous search space $\mathbb{X} \subset [0, 1]^n$ which is a subset of the n -dimensional real numbers to the space $\mathbb{Y}$ of permutations of the first n natural numbers^{12,13}. For example, on $n = 5$, the vector $x = (0.49, 0.91, 0.33, 0.75, 0.51)$ is translated to the permutation $y = (3, 1, 5, 4, 2)$, because $x_3 = 0.33$ has the smallest value, putting 3 at the beginning, $x_1 = 0.49$ the second-smallest, placing 1 second, ..., and $x_2 = 0.91$ being the largest value meaning that the last number in y will be 2¹³. The advantage of the encoding is that we can search in $\mathbb{X}$ applying arbitrary mathematical operators, crossover, and mutation procedures, but will always get correct permutations. The disadvantage is that $|\mathbb{X}| \gg |\mathbb{Y}|$ and that there actually is no meaning underpinning moves in $\mathbb{X}$ in relation to their projected result in $\mathbb{Y}$.

RLS Randomized local search retains the best solution x_c discovered so far during the search and, in each step, it applies a unary search operator to this best-so-far solution x_c and derives a new solution x_n . If the new solution x_n is *better or equally good* when compared with x_c , i.e., not worse, then it replaces it, i.e., is stored as the new x_c . If the search space are bit strings of length n , then RLS uses a unary search operator that flips exactly one bit. This operator is the main difference to $(1 + 1)$ EA.

FRLS The RLS with FFA plugged in²¹⁷. On the discrete bit-string domains, this algorithm has a very specific structure: Its unary search operator flips exactly one bit, distinguishing it from the unary operator in the $(1 + 1)$ FEA, which flips each bit with probability $1/n$. On other domains, such as permutations, we use the term synonymously with $(1 + 1)$ FEA.

Glossary XI



RTS *Reactive Tabu Search* is a variant of TS where the length of the tabu list is adapted to the problem and to the current evolution of the search, and an escape strategy for diversifying the search is used when that is not sufficient⁸⁻¹¹. It has successfully been applied to a wide range of problems, from the QAP^{9,10}, to Knapsack problems^{8,10}, the N-K landscape⁸ to the training of neural networks¹¹.

SA *Simulated Annealing* is a SLS that sometimes accepts a worse solution^{34,103,110,160,197}. The probability to do so decreases over time and with the difference in objective values, i.e., is the lower the worse the new solution is. SA performed well on a variety of problems, including the QAP^{145,189} and the JSSP¹⁵⁶.

SATLIB is a library of benchmark instances for the Maximum Satisfiability (MaxSAT) available at <https://www.cs.ubc.ca/~hoos/SATLIB/index-ubc.html>^{96,97}.

SLS *Stochastic local search* is a local search (LS), one of the simplest metaheuristic search paradigms⁹⁵: A single “current” candidate solution is maintained and new solutions are *stochastically* sampled from its neighborhood, i.e., in a way that involves random numbers. If these solutions are deemed interesting based on their objective value, they replace the “current”. The cycle continues. Basic examples are RLS and $(1 + 1)$ EA. More complex examples that add mechanisms to escape local optima on top of the SLS paradigm are TS and SA.

SOTA State-of-the-Art, i.e., the best-performing methods for a field or problem type

STSP *A symmetric Traveling Salesperson Problem* is a special case of the TSP, where the $n \times n$ distance matrix A is symmetric, i.e., $A[a, b] = A[b, a] \forall a, b \in 1..n$.

Trap The Trap problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{61,151,217}. It is structured exactly like OneMax, however the worst and the best solution are swapped. This makes the problem highly deceptive, as following the “gradient” in the search space leads the search away from the global optimum. For bit strings of length n , the objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is 0 if $\|x\|_1 = 0$ and $n - \|x\|_1 - 1$ otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^n x_i$. An $(1 + 1)$ EA will converge to the resulting local optimum and thus have an expected runtime of $\Theta(n^n)$ ⁶¹. In experiments, the $(1 + 1)$ FEA achieves polynomial runtime on Trap, seemingly in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ ^{207,208,217}.

Glossary XII



TS *Tabu Search* is one of the most successful SLSes^{80,81,83,105}. In order to avoid returning to previous solutions, it declares certain solutions or search moves as “tabu.” For example, if a bit in a discrete problem has been flipped by the search operator, it may be forbidden to flip the bit again for some time, thus preventing the algorithm from getting trapped in a cycle. This rule may be overridden if a new best-so-far solution is discovered that outperforms all previous solutions, in which case it would be accepted (this is the so-called aspiration criterion). TS has performed well on the QAP^{9,10,144,147,183,184} and on the JSSP^{152,158,159,176,218}.

TSP In an instance of the *Traveling Salesperson Problem*, also known as *Traveling Salesman Problem*, a set of n cities or locations as well as the distances between them are given^{4,90,121,125,201,209}. The goal is to find the shortest round-trip tour that starts at one city, visits all the other cities one time each, and returns to the origin. The TSP is one of the most well-known $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard combinatorial optimization problems^{78,90,117}. The TSP has many applications⁴, including in transportation, logistics, (circuit) plotting and drilling problems⁹⁹, telescope aiming, and genome sequencing. Solutions are often encoded as permutations x of the first n natural numbers, where each city gets a number and the order of numbers in the permutation corresponds to the order of cities in the tour. The distances between the n cities are usually given in a $n \times n$ distance matrix A , where $A[a, b]$ is the distance from city a to city b with $a, b \in 1..n$. Then, the objective function subject to minimization is $f(x) = A[x_n, x_1] + \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} A[x_i, x_{i+1}]$. Typical benchmark instances can be found in TSPLib^{168,169}, the 8th DIMACS challenge^{106–108}, and the *World TSP* repository⁴³.

TSPLib is a library of benchmark instances for the Traveling Salesperson Problem (TSP)^{168,169}. Its original URL was available until 2025 and then became defunct. The repository <https://github.com/shredderzsj/TSPLIB> contains the data. Additionally, you may also check <https://github.com/thomasWeise/tspSuite>, which contains all the TSPLib instances as well as Java code to load them. The TSPLib contains 110 instances of the symmetric Traveling Salesperson Problems (STSPs) with scales n ranging from 14 to 85 900, but 93 instances have less than 2000 nodes. There also are 19 asymmetric Traveling Salesperson Problems (ATSPs) with scales $n \in 17..443$.

Glossary XIII



TTP The *Traveling Tournament Problem* is the combinatorial optimization problem of both efficiently and fairly organizing a tournament of n teams that play against each other in a pairwise fashion^{64,213}. The efficient part boils down to arranging the games such that the total travel length is short, which is somewhat similar to the classical TSP. Initially, each team is at its home location. On each day, a team needs to travel if its scheduled game is not at its present location. On the last day, each team may need to travel back home unless their last game is a home game. The total travel length sums up the lengths of all travels over all teams. The fair part is represented in several constraints, such as doubleRoundRobin, compactness, maxStreak, and noRepeat. The TTP is $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard¹⁹⁴.

TwoMax The TwoMax problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search^{76,192,217}. It has a global and a local optimum, both of about the same size, at opposite ends of the search space. For bit strings of length n , the objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is 0 if $\|x\|_1 = n$ and $1 + n - \max\{\|x\|_1, n - \|x\|_1\}$ otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^n x_i$. An $(1 + 1)$ EA has a 50/50 chance to converge to the local or global optimum and thus has an expected runtime in $\Theta(n^n)$ ^{75,76}. In experiments, the $(1 + 1)$ FEA achieves polynomial runtime seemingly in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ on TwoMax^{207,208,217}.

URI A *Uniform Resource Identifier* is an identifier for an abstract or physical resource in the internet²¹⁶. It can be a URL, a name, or both. URIs are supersets of URLs. The connection strings of the PostgreSQL DBMS are examples for URIs.

URL A *Uniform Resource Locator* identifies a resource in the World Wide Web (WWW) and a way to obtain it by describing a network access mechanism. The most notable example of URLs is the text you write into web browsers to visit websites¹⁹. URLs are subsets of Uniform Resource Identifiers (URIs).

VND *Variable Neighborhood Descend*; see VNS. VND in combination with GRASP has been applied to the 2BP|O|F in¹⁵⁷.

Glossary XIV



VNS *Variable Neighborhood Search* is a metaheuristic framework combining a systematic change of neighborhood with LS^{91,148}. A *neighborhood* structure in LS defines which solutions can be reached from a given solution within one search step. Usually, one uses a single unary operator and, hence, has a single neighborhood structure. However, for many problems, we can easily design many operators. For permutations, for example, one operator may swap two elements, another one may reverse a section of the permutation, and yet another one, while yet another one may rotate a subsequence one step to the left or right²⁰¹. In the VNS framework, a multiple neighborhoods are investigated in a systematic fashion. Assume that we have a list of neighborhood structures. Variable Neighborhood Descend (VND) works in a deterministic fashion. It finds the best solution that can be reached in one step from the current solution under the current neighborhood. If this is better than the current solution, we accept it and continue with the first neighborhood. Otherwise, we continue with the next neighborhood in the list. In Basic VNS, instead of picking the best move from the current neighborhood, the first improving move is used. Also, at the beginning of each cycle, a random point from the current neighborhood around the current solution is chosen as starting point.

WWW World Wide Web^{18,47}

$\circ^*$ the superscript $\star$ symbol denotes that $\circ$ is a global optimum, i.e., there is no better solution than $\circ$.

$i..j$ with $i, j \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $i \leq j$ is the set that contains all integer numbers in the inclusive range from i to j . For example, $5..9$ is equivalent to $\{5, 6, 7, 8, 9\}$

A the $n \times n$ distance matrix. $A[a, b]$ indicates the distance between locations a and b with $a, b \in 1..n$. A distance matrix can be symmetric, in which case $A[a, b] = A[b, a] \forall a, b \in 1..n$. Distance matrices represent the problem instance data in TSPs and part of the instance data of QAPs.

B the $n \times n$ flow matrix. $B[a, b]$ is the flow of goods between locations a and b with $a, b \in 1..n$. Flow matrices are one half of the problem instance data of QAPs.

Glossary XV



- $f(y)$ The *objective function* $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ can compute a cost or rating for each candidate solution y in the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$. The smaller this value, the better the solution, i.e., in the context of this work, objective functions are subject to minimization. Objective functions are not necessarily continuous and it is also quite common that they have integer or natural numbers as results, e.g., we often have $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{N}_0$ instead of $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$.
- $\gamma(x)$ The decoding function $\gamma : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{Y}$ translates point from the search space $\mathbb{X}$ to one point y in the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$. It is a very common case that $\mathbb{X} = \mathbb{Y}$ and that the decoding function γ is the identity mapping. Examples for encodings that translate from a simple search space $\mathbb{X}$ to a complex solution data structure $\mathbb{Y}$ are the IBL algorithm that translates (potentially signed) permutations to two-dimensional packings on the 2BP, the permutation-based encoding of Gantt charts for the JSSP from ^{21,22,79,174,202}, or the permutation-based encoding of game plans for the TTP from ²¹³. Encodings can also translate between types of search spaces. The Random Keys encoding, for example, translates from $[0, 1]^n$ to permutations of the first n natural numbers..
- k the number of jobs in an instance of the JSSP.
- m the number of machines in an instance of the JSSP.
- n We usually use n to denote the scale, i.e., the size of the problem to solve. For example, in a TSP, this may be the number of cities, in a discrete benchmark problem such as OneMax or Trap, this may be the number of bits over which the problem is defined, in a QAP, this may be the number of facilities and locations, and in a MaxSAT problem, this may be the number of variables that are input to the Boolean formula that we want to become true. There are also problems where the scale is not defined straightforwardly like this. For example, in a JSSP, we have a number of machines and a number of jobs, which together define the size of the problem. But even then, the scale n relates to the size of the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$, and, hence, also of the search space $\mathbb{X}$, which usually grow exponentially with n . And this is already the main issue: The larger n , the (exponentially) larger the number of possible solutions and thus, the larger the runtime of algorithms..
- $\mathbb{N}_0$ the set of the natural numbers *including* 0, i.e., 0, 1, 2, 3, and so on. It holds that $\mathbb{N}_0 \subset \mathbb{Z}$.

Glossary XVI



$\mathbb{N}_1$ the set of the natural numbers *excluding* 0, i.e., 1, 2, 3, 4, and so on. It holds that $\mathbb{N}_1 \subset \mathbb{Z}$.

$\mathcal{NP}$ is the class of computational problems that can be solved in polynomial time by a non-deterministic machine and can be verified in polynomial time by a deterministic machine (such as a normal computer) ⁸⁷.

$\mathcal{NP}$ -complete A decision problem is $\mathcal{NP}$ -complete if it is in $\mathcal{NP}$ and all problems in $\mathcal{NP}$ are reducible to it in polynomial time ^{87,166}. A problem is $\mathcal{NP}$ -complete if it is $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard and if it is in $\mathcal{NP}$.

$\mathcal{NP}$ -hard A problem is $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard if all problems in $\mathcal{NP}$ are reducible to it in polynomial time ⁸⁷. Algorithms that guarantee to find the correct solutions of $\mathcal{NP}$ -hard problems ^{35,40,120} have a worst-case runtime that grows exponentially with the problem scale.

$\Omega(g(x))$ If $f(x) = \Omega(g(x))$, then there exist positive numbers $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^+$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}^+$ such that $f(x) \geq c * g(x) \geq 0 \forall x \geq x_0$ ^{112,113}. In other words, $\Omega(g(x))$ describes a lower bound for function growth.

$\mathcal{O}(g(x))$ If $f(x) = \mathcal{O}(g(x))$, then there exist positive numbers $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^+$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}^+$ such that $0 \leq f(x) \leq c * g(x) \forall x \geq x_0$ ^{6,112,113,118}. In other words, $\mathcal{O}(g(x))$ describes an upper bound for function growth.

$\Theta(g(x))$ If $f(x) = \Theta(g(x))$, then $f(x) = \mathcal{O}(g(x))$ and $f(x) = \Omega(g(x))$ ^{112,113}. In other words, $\Theta(g(x))$ describes an exact order of function growth.

$\mathbb{R}$ the set of the real numbers.

$\mathbb{R}^+$ the set of the positive real numbers, i.e., $\mathbb{R}^+ = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x > 0\}$.

$\mathbb{Y}$ the set of candidate solutions of an optimization problem is called the *solution space* $\mathbb{Y}$. The solution space corresponds to the data structure holding the candidate solutions y . These are the elements that are passed to the user after the optimization process is completed. They are also the parameters of the objective function(s) $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$.

y a candidate solution $y \in \mathbb{Y}$ is one possible solution to an optimization problem. After the optimization process is completed, one or multiple such solutions are passed to the user.

$\mathbb{Z}$ the set of the integers numbers including positive and negative numbers and 0, i.e., $\dots, -3, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, 3, \dots$, and so on. It holds that $\mathbb{Z} \subset \mathbb{R}$.